

RELIGION

Medieval people had very firm religious beliefs. Europe was mostly Christian, but there were some Jews, and the Middle East was mainly Muslim.



RELIGIOUS IMAGE

This 13th-century stained-glass window was made for a French royal chapel.



THE CRUSADES

In a long-running series of wars called the Crusades, Christian European armies tried to drive Muslim rulers out of the Holy Land. They captured Jerusalem, only to lose the city again later.

ROUTES BY LAND AND SEA

- 1st Crusade, 1096–99
- 2nd Crusade, 1145–49
- 3rd Crusade, 1189–92
- 4th Crusade, 1202–04

TIMELINE

There is no clear beginning or end to the medieval period. Generally, it is dated from around the late 5th century to the middle of the 15th century.



Symbol of Islam

570
Muhammad, Islam's most important prophet, is born.

793
Vikings from Denmark, Norway, and Sweden begin their raids in northern Europe.



French fortress built for William the Conqueror

1066
William the Conqueror of Normandy conquers the English at Hastings and becomes king of England.



Church inside Crusader fortress

1206
The Mongol Empire is founded by Genghis Khan.

1431
French heroine Joan of Arc is executed by the English and their French allies at the age of 19.

1453
The Turks take Constantinople, last outpost of the Eastern Roman Empire. This marks the approximate end of the Middle Ages.

450

476
The Roman Empire in Western Europe ends. This is the approximate start of the medieval era also known as the Middle Ages.

732
At the Battle of Tours, European armies defeat Muslim invaders.



12th-century statue of Charlemagne

800
Charlemagne crowns himself emperor of Western Europe and builds a vast empire.

896
Alfred the Great defeats the Vikings, saving England from invasion.



Jewel with portrait of Alfred the Great

1096
Christian Crusaders start a long period of religious wars in the Holy Land.

1191
Richard I (the "Lionheart"), king of England, defeats Saladin, great ruler of Egypt and Syria.



Richard the Lionheart

1347
The disease called the Black Death begins and will kill about half the people in Europe.

1440s
German craftsman Johannes Gutenberg invents the printing press.

1500

JOUSTING

A mock one-to-one fight on horseback, jousting was a dangerous sport. Two knights charged at one another, each trying to unseat the other with his lance.



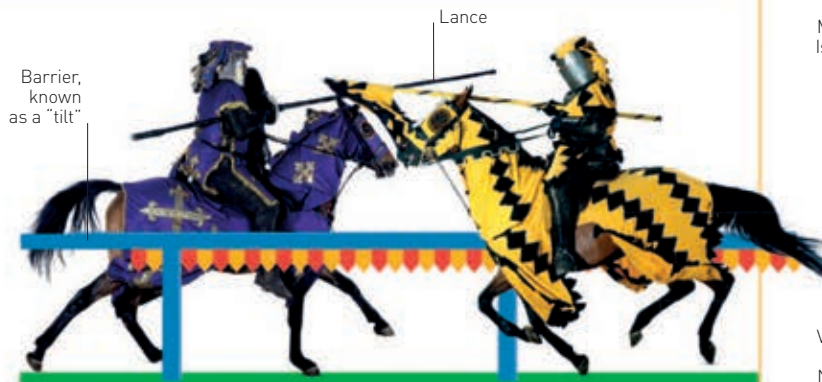
JOUSTING HELMET



VAMPLATE (HAND GUARD)



LOCKING-GAUNTLET



ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

In the 12th century, knights wore chain-mail armour made from linked iron rings. By the 15th century, battledress was more often a suit of steel plates. Men fought with swords and long-handled weapons such as pikes and axes.



GILDED PLATE ARMOUR



PLATE ARMOUR



CUIRASSIER



ARMET



BURGONET



BASINET



MAIL HELMET



MAIL JACKET



HORSE HEAD ARMOUR



BATTLE AXE



POLE AXE



WAR HAMMER



PICK



HAND CANNON

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

The law in medieval times was very brutal. Cruel instruments of torture were used both as punishments and to force people to admit guilt or divulge information. Many castles had a torture chamber hidden in their lower depths.



NECK SPIKER



THUMBSCREWS



IRON MASK



MOUTH SCREW